Hindutva mobilisation, Shah's promise of an eighty-foot statue of the Nishad king was meant to draw the caste to the BJP's political project, while complementing its own ethno-religious mobilisation effort. The Yogi Adityanath government committed to building this statue at Shringverpur, near Allahabad, because that was the spot where local folklore believed Ram had crossed the river and it was said to mark the capital of the ancient Nishad kingdom.[24]

The party 'opened the horse stables'[25] for Nishads, who are influential in about twenty UP Lok Sabha constituencies, after it suffered an unexpected reverse in the Gorakhpur parliamentary by-election of March 2018.[26] It famously lost Gorakhpur—the citadel of Yogi Adityanath and a seat which he, and his adopted father before him, had not lost since 1984—to a Nishad candidate in the by-election forced by Adityanath's vacation of the seat to become chief minister of UP. That 2018 victory of Praveen Nishad, son of Nishad Party founder Sanjay Nishad, who fought on behalf of SP, sent a serious warning signal to the BJP ahead of the 2019 general election. It marked the first coming together of bitter rivals SP and BSP in a Mahagathbandhan, or Grand Alliance, previously unthinkable in UP politics. The success of the alliance in the strongest of BJP seats in the state—Gorakhpur has long been among the highest-margin seats for the BJP in the country—demonstrated that caste arithmetic could best the personality-based alchemy of politics and Hindu mobilisation. So the BJP refocused its own caste coalition at the ground level. Within a year, Praveen Nishad, the man who had felled the BJP in the chief minister's hometown, had himself switched to the BJP.[27] Ironically, he gave up the Gorakhpur seat and fought the 2019 election as a BJP candidate from the nearby seat of Sant Kabir Nagar, and won again—this time as a saffron candidate.[28]

Reclassifying Castes: Yogi Adityanath's Policy Moves on OBCs

The BJP further wooed non-Yadav OBC castes in 2019 with two promises. The first was the Yogi Adityanath-led state government's decision to accept the demands of seventeen non-Yadav OBC castes to reclassify them as SCs (traditionally considered lower